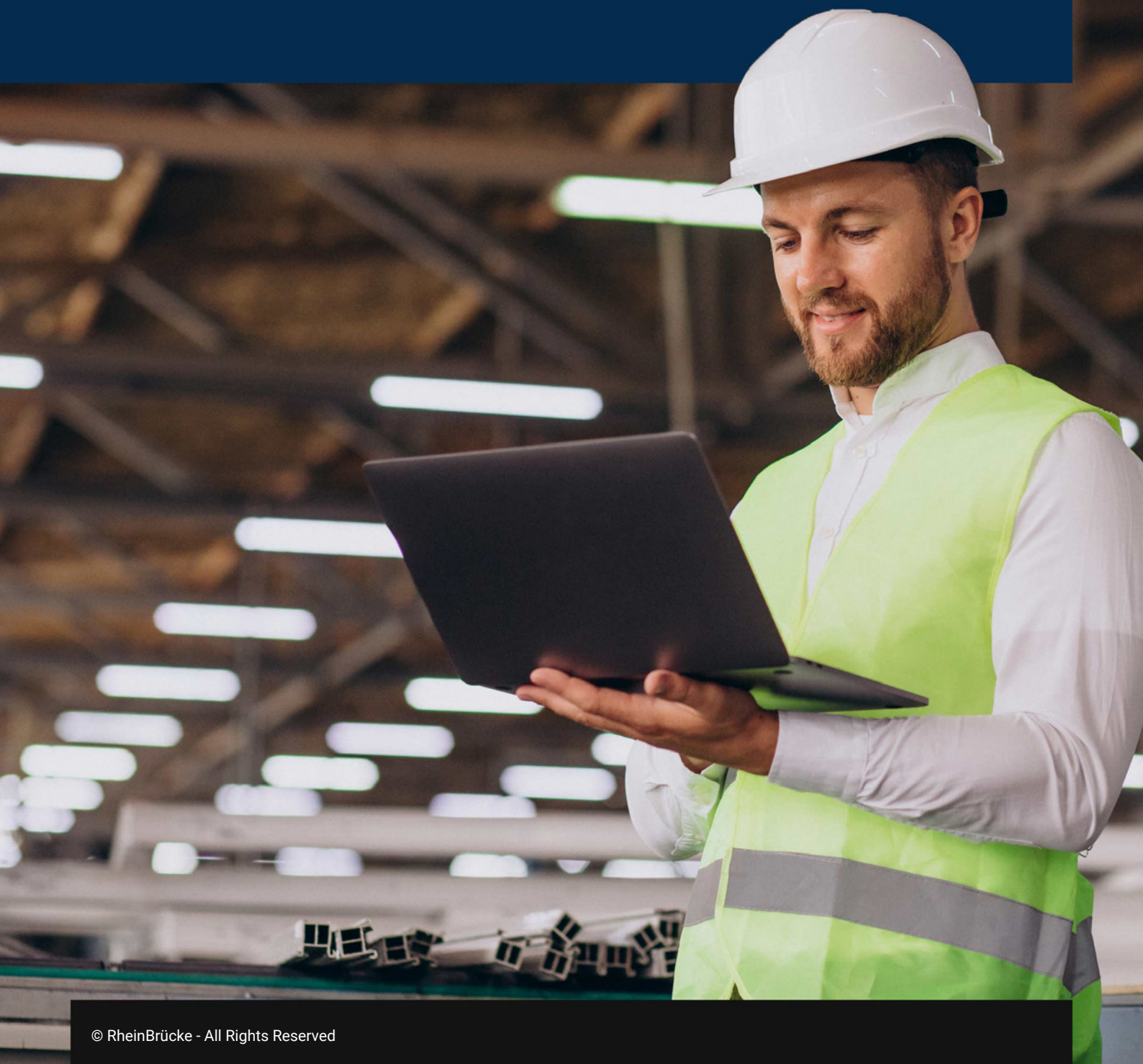


ERP Guide 2024

A RheinBrücke Whitepaper



Content

Introduction	01
ERP Market Trends	02
Top ERP trends to Look for in 2024 and Beyond	03
Top ERP Contenders to Consider	06
Epicor Kinetic	06
IFS	07
Infor	08
Microsoft Dynamics 365	08
Oracle	09
SAP	09
A Quick Comparison of Top ERPs	10
Choosing your ERP – Next Steps	12
Epicor ERP in Comparison to Other Leading ERP Solutions in the Market	14
RheinBrücke's Epicor Solutions	16
Conclusion	17

Introduction

The past couple of years have proven beyond doubt that an ERP system is not just a good to have software to improve efficiency, but a must-have to survive in a world of uncertainties and volatile economic and political conditions.. Under these circumstances, businesses need to take a digital-first approach and leverage their enterprise applications in a manner that enables them to run business smarter, be more agile, and make decisions at lightning speed to ensure improved performance. An ERP is a gateway towards a more flexible and agile workforce, which will enable companies to aim for zero downtime, improved resource productivity, and overall better process optimization.

Furthermore, Cloud solutions have made ERP systems more accessible for small to medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) enabling them to leverage the numerous benefits of implementing an ERP system at a reasonable cost and without having to worry about huge infrastructure requirements that were needed for On-premise deployment of huge ERP solutions. It is no wonder that the majority of companies have either implemented or are looking to implement an ERP in the near future to build resilience.

However, like any other technology, it is essential to keep on top of ERP systems' features and solutions. It is important to note that ERPs have come such a long way from their early inception days that the older versions are quickly becoming obsolete. Companies are moving from legacy to newer ERP platforms to gain traction in the digital ecosystem. Enterprise resource planning solutions have matured and expanded their reach to support most business functions, from back-end processes like Accounting, HR, Procurement and Manufacturing to front-office functions such as Sales Force Automation, Marketing Automation and eCommerce.

“An IDC report says by 2025, 80% of organizations responding to the digital-first economy will require advanced enterprise applications with exceptional innovation, multifunctional capabilities, and self-learning aspects”

As companies increasingly rely on ERP to run their businesses, ERP vendors too continue to evolve in incorporating new technologies and supporting a broader range of functions. The application of big data, artificial intelligence, IOT, machine learning, conversational user interface (UI), virtual assistants/chatbots, predictive analytics, and natural language processing means organizations can leverage these modern, modular, and intelligent enterprise applications to greater levers for their advantage.

However, choosing an ERP that meets your business needs and enables you to leverage these latest technologies from the numerous solutions available today can be quite overwhelming.

The following criteria were considered through the ranking process to determine the best-performing systems.

- ✓ Breadth and depth of functionality
- ✓ Flexibility of solutions
- ✓ Scalability of solutions
- ✓ Customer adoption rate
- ✓ Ease of implementation, including average time and total cost of ownership
- ✓ Maturity of cloud solutions
- ✓ Ease of integration to third-party systems
- ✓ Vendor's product roadmap and overall viability
- ✓ Ease of organizational change management and training
- ✓ Strength of vendor ecosystem, such as system integrators and partners
- ✓ Return on investment

In this whitepaper, we bring to you the top contenders in the ERP market in the year gone by and the top trends to keep an eye on in the ERP space in 2024 and beyond.

ERP Market Trends

The global enterprise resource planning (ERP) software market is forecast to grow to around 101 billion U.S. dollars by 2026 due to the accelerated move of digital transformation and cloud. This will be predominantly driven by increased demand for supply chain platforms, analytics platforms and CRM systems in the enterprises' efforts to improve business processes, sustain business and enhance customer experience. Gartner expects the adoption of cloud ERP for manufacturing and supply chain operations by even the larger organizations to accelerate over the next few years.

A report from Finances Online in 2023 reveals a sizeable portion of ERP users, around 33.66% are from Manufacturing, followed by Information Technology (14.85%), Professional or Financial services (13.86%), Distribution or Wholesale (9.90%), Public sector and Non profit (6.93%), Healthcare (4.95%), Retail (3.96%),

Utilities (3.96%), Construction (1.98%), Mining (1.98%), Education(0.99%) and Transportation (0.99%). In fact, this is mainly because manufacturing companies were some of the earliest adopters of ERP systems. For manufacturers dealing with a complex supply chain, a robust and modern ERP system is now widely recognized as playing a crucial role in enhancing efficiency and improving customer experience. There are a growing number of organizations in the healthcare, construction and retail industry sectors implementing end-to-end business management solutions. The survey also discovered that efficiency and mobility are the critical parameters for most industries as firms rushed to implement top ERP systems and related process optimization projects. ERP vendors are also transitioning into SaaS or incorporating best-of-breed applications within their core packages so they can support more niche best practices.

Main ERP Users

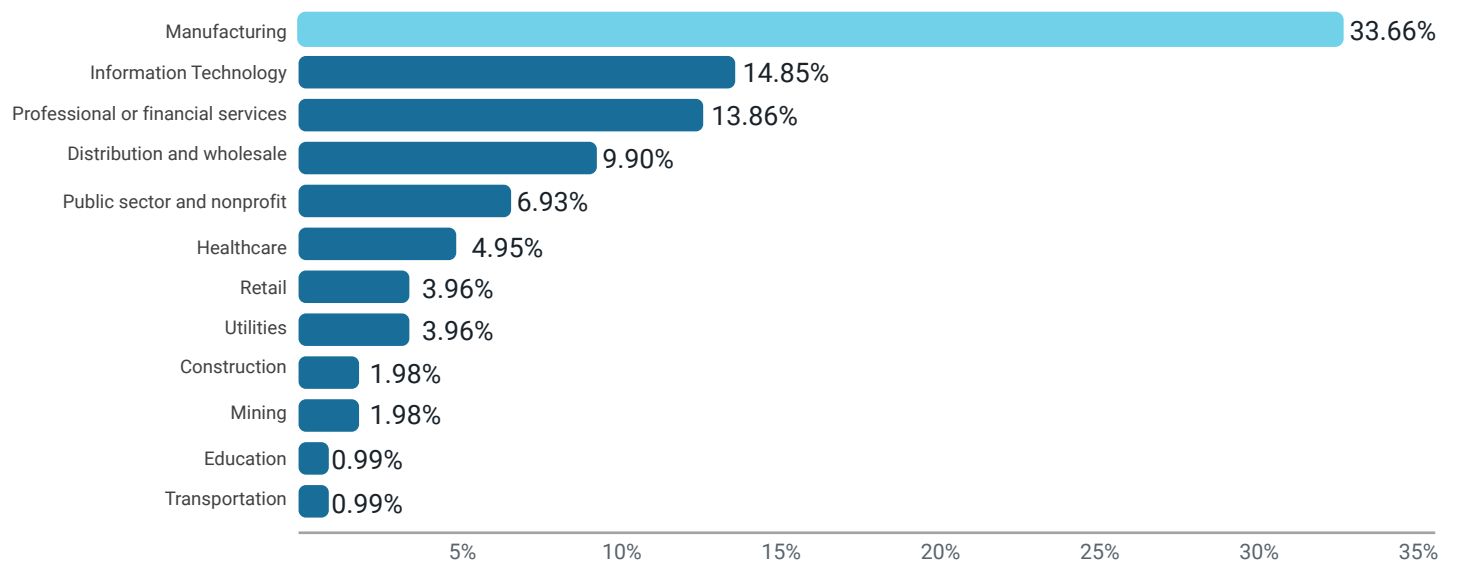


Image Source: Finances online 2023 Report

The cloud deployment option along with increased usability has driven the growth of ERPs in the smaller and mid-sized companies' segment as well. Research reports that 85% of manufacturers identify ERP as being a vital platform to delivering positive customer experiences. Reduced cost and rapid implementation contribute to making ERP a viable resource for companies of all sizes. Manufacturing companies are especially well-positioned to benefit from the intelligence gathered from this data, as they can use it to optimize operations, improve profits and fuel new growth.

In the past year, there has also been an increased adoption of Cloud ERP. Panorama Consulting's report says more than half of organizations are selecting cloud software instead of on-premise software. And more than three-quarters of organizations that selected cloud ERP used a SaaS model as opposed to a hosted model.

Top ERP trends to Look for in 2024 and Beyond

Over the past year, we have witnessed a transformative shift in the landscape of work, marked by challenges such as talent scarcity, the Great Resignation, and the widespread adoption of remote and distributed workforces. These factors have acted as catalysts, propelling the adoption of cloud-based ERP solutions. Organizations are now driven by the imperative to achieve greater efficiency and automation in their operations, doing more with fewer resources. These objectives have evolved from being desirable to becoming essential.

In this context, the integration of AI, IoT, and composable ERP systems is poised to gain momentum rapidly. Businesses that not only survived but thrived in 2023 were those that demonstrated exceptional adaptability and harnessed the capabilities of modern ERP systems to drive innovation and adapt to changing circumstances.

So, what criteria should you consider when evaluating your next ERP solution? What shifts have occurred in the ERP landscape, and what trends should you be aware of? Take a closer look at the following ERP trends for 2024, and assess whether it's time to incorporate some of these new capabilities into your business software arsenal.



Cloud is Everywhere

The advantages of cloud-based Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP) solutions have been recognized for some time, but in the wake of recent and pressing challenges, the demand for these systems is experiencing a significant surge. Cloud ERP software, by its very nature, has the capacity to impact virtually every facet of an organization, positioning it as the most expeditious route to achieving comprehensive digital transformation and unlocking advanced business capabilities.

One of the prominent advantages of cloud ERP is its ability to offer heightened accessibility and scalability. Consider, for instance, a small manufacturing company seeking to adapt and thrive in a dynamic business environment. With cloud ERP in place, this organization gains the capability to access critical data remotely. This not only facilitates real-time collaboration among multiple locations but also empowers the business to expand seamlessly and efficiently.

By embracing cloud ERP, companies can break down geographical barriers and enable cross-functional teams to work collaboratively, irrespective of their physical location. Moreover, the scalability inherent in cloud ERP systems ensures that businesses can easily adjust their operations to accommodate growth and evolving market demands.

A research from MarketandReports.com suggests that the global market is expected to nearly double to \$130 billion by 2027 from \$64.7 billion in 2022.

Artificial Intelligence and other Intelligent Technology

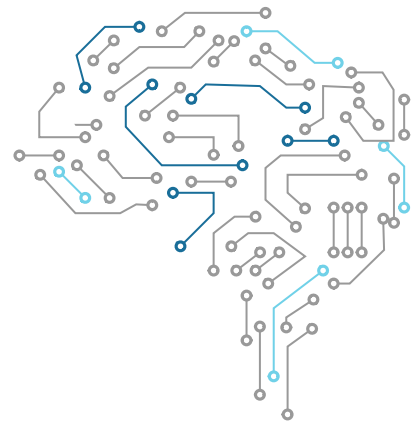
Artificial Intelligence (AI) has been the talk of the town for a few years now. In the last 5 years, AI and Machine Learning (ML) technology has steadily trickled down into every industry, infusing their systems and platforms with new possibilities. We will see an explosive growth of AI in the ERP and business applications landscape.

According to Gartner's Top Strategic Technology Trends, 2022 report, by 2025, the 10% of enterprises that establish AI

engineering best practices will generate at least three times more value from their AI efforts than the 90% of enterprises that do not.

AI provides game-changing solutions to enable organizations to emerge from the pandemic in a strong position, but merely adopting AI won't do it. Organizations must optimize AI. ERP solutions reinforced with built-in artificial intelligence leveraging big data and advanced analytics will be key to accelerating business decision-making.

An IDC Report says,



“ Responding to the reality of Digital Disruption, by 2023, 60% of businesses will embrace a decision-making model that combines the power of AI and human judgement for more ”



Sustainability Integration with ERP

The integration of sustainability and the consideration of Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) factors are becoming increasingly prominent within the realm of Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP) solutions. Companies are not only adopting sustainable practices to safeguard natural resources but also recognizing the pivotal role of ESG criteria in determining long-term commercial viability. ERP systems that encompass sustainability metrics are poised to provide organizations with the means to gauge their performance in alignment with ESG standards, thereby facilitating ongoing enhancements and safeguarding their competitive standing in the market.

As businesses grow more attuned to their environmental impact, ERP systems are progressively evolving to encompass sustainable methodologies. This entails the incorporation of tools designed to monitor and manage sustainability objectives, including reduction in energy consumption, carbon emissions, water usage, and waste generation. By seamlessly integrating sustainability data, businesses gain the capability to make more informed decisions regarding their environmental footprint. This shift toward sustainable ERP not only reflects a commitment to responsible corporate citizenship but also serves as a strategic approach to enhance environmental stewardship and long-term resilience.

Internet of Things

Integrating IoT Edge computing devices to ERP is gaining traction across industries, especially in Supply Chain, Logistics, Warehouse Management and Manufacturing. With integrated IoT, companies can gather, analyze, and process a vast amount of information through sensors. Similarly, businesses can gain real-time insights into machine performance and closely monitor production processes. According to Gartner, businesses are expected to integrate 8.4 billion IoT devices into their operations. This trend will further accelerate as nations start to roll out 5G services in the next few years.





Mobile ERP

One of the major trends in the ERP space is complete mobile support. It has in fact become one of the basic expectations from a modern ERP tool. A mobile-ready ERP brings a plethora of benefits including on-the-go access enabling employees to gather or key in information from the field or wherever they are, eliminating delays and ensuring the availability of accurate data.

Growing Demand for Niche Solutions

As organizations are evolving at a rapid pace, experts say that generic ERP systems might not be capable of addressing the requirements of such businesses. Organizations might not really have the time to customize these generic solutions based on their business processes. Hence, there is a growing demand for niche solutions – plug and play ERP systems that are intended for specific industries. An industry specific ERP solution will have the features and functionalities required for companies operating in the industry. Thus, it eliminates customizations and shortens implementation time and results in quicker adoption than a generic ERP.



Moreover, vendors providing industry vertical solutions usually have a good knowledge of the domain and can provide assistance in optimizing business processes based on industry best practices and thus enabling users to realize their business goals faster. ERP vendors are also working towards creating hyper-niche ERP solutions which further drill down to sub-verticals of industries to offer even more specialized solutions.

Thus, 2023 and beyond, companies looking for a new ERP should look for more than just an ERP. Rather than focusing on the system itself, organizations should also look at how the ERP system fits within the rest of their infrastructure, their business goals and the industry trends.

Top ERP Contenders to Consider

As companies increasingly rely on ERP software to run their businesses, ERP vendors too continue to evolve incorporating new technologies to support a broader range of functions. With technologies like IoT, Blockchain, Business Intelligence, Machine Learning, and AI rewriting rules for businesses, choosing an ERP system that meets your business needs and enables you to leverage these latest technologies is more important than ever before. The ERP vendors mentioned below have been short-listed based on their technology, features, user reviews, product viability, etc. So, here is the list of top 7 ERP vendors for 2023 in alphabetical order.

Epicor Kinetic

Epicor ERP is one of the best ERP software vendors providing industry-specific solutions built to cater to the needs of organizations of all sizes in different industries including Manufacturing, Automotive, Distribution, Retail, and Building Supply. Epicor announced a total rebranding of its cloud-based ERP solution in 2021. The Epicor ERP rebrand relaunched the platform as Kinetic. In addition, Epicor has added new features to the platform, including a new browser-based UI that's accessible via any mobile device, an Application Studio tool offering low-no code customization options, and an updated visual designer.

Epicor is especially suited for midmarket companies. It has been positioned as a Leader in the Gartner Magic Quadrant for Cloud ERP for Product-Centric Enterprises 2023. Additionally, Epicor received the highest score in the ERP Functionality use case in Gartner's Critical Capabilities report for Cloud ERP for Product-Centric Midsize Enterprises and Panorama Consulting's ERP report identifies it as the top performer in the midmarket.

Epicor is a fully integrated end-to-end ERP solution with comprehensive features and functionalities to automate various business processes with its modules such as accounting and finance management, customer relationship management, inventory management, pre-production materials planning, HR management, supply chain management, governance, risk and compliance management, product and production management, sales and marketing, Business Intelligence, etc. Customers can choose the modules they need based on their business requirements.

Epicor offers flexible deployment options - on-premise, hosted or cloud. It also allows for multi-site installations for organizations operating from multiple locations.

Epicor at a Glance

Company Name: **Epicor Software**

Founded: **1972**

Headquarters: **Austin, Texas**

Ownership: **Private**

Customers: **20,000+**

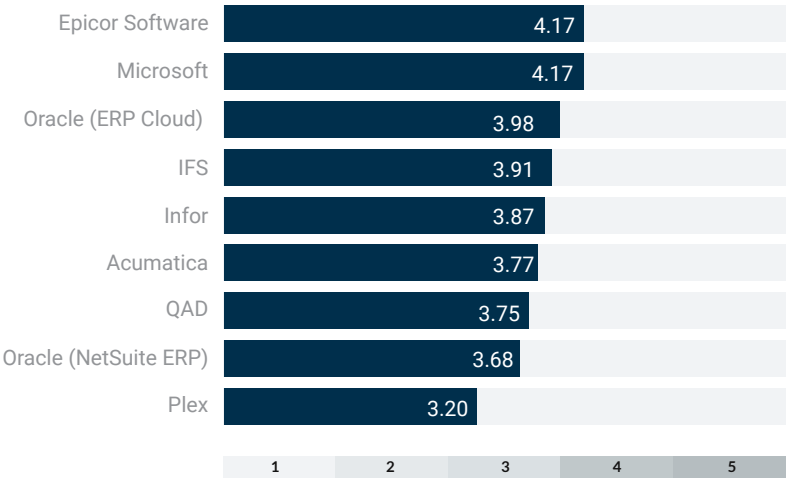
Deployment Model: **Cloud, On-Premise**

Organization Suitability: **Mid-sized to large**

Modules: **Materials Management, Sales & Order Management, Financial Management, Production Management, Supply Chain Management, Customer Relationship Management, Enterprise Performance Management, Human Resource Management**

It also has vertical industry-specific solutions tailored for the needs of manufacturing sectors like automotive, aerospace & defense, construction & engineering, fabricated metals, industrial machinery, discrete manufacturing, process manufacturing, medical device, rubber & plastics, furniture and fixtures, etc. Epicor scored highest in the ERP Functionality use case in Gartner’s Critical Capabilities report for Cloud ERP for Product-Centric Midsize Enterprises.

With top-notch technologies like AI, IoT, Virtual Assistant (EVA) and BI available out-of-the-box, Epicor ERP is a future-ready ERP software. It offers high mobility and extensibility allowing businesses to easily scale and make better decisions to keep pace with evolving industry trends.



Product or Service Scores for ERP Functionality for Midsize Enterprises

As of 22 June, 2020
Source: Gartner (July 2020)

IFS

IFS offers ERP solutions for industries including aerospace & defense, utilities & resources, construction & infrastructure, manufacturing, and services industry. It is designed for mid to large-sized organizations and can be deployed on-premise or in the cloud.

The solution includes functionalities for Enterprise Project Management, Enterprise Asset Management, and Service Management. IFS ERP application can be configured for a variety of industries and is specifically suitable for businesses demanding processes that combine elements of manufacturing, project, service, and asset management. Customers can pick the modules they need and add them on as and when they need them.

IFS ERP applications also incorporate advanced technologies such as the Internet of Things (IoT), Natural Language Processing (through IFS Aurena Bot), and analytics directly into the product applications. Customers looking for differentiating capabilities in asset management may find them in IFS ERP, with the vendor coming in above average in the project/asset-intensive manufacturing use case.

IFS at a Glance

- Company Name: **IFS**
- Founded: **1983**
- Headquarters: **Linköping, Sweden**
- Ownership: **Private**
- Customers: **10,000+**
- Deployment Model: **Cloud, On-Premise**
- Modules: Finance, Human Capital Management, Commerce, Customer Relationship Management, Manufacturing, Supply Chain Management, Procurement, Projects

Infor

Infor CloudSuite is a robust suite of industry-specific ERP applications primarily intended for mid-sized and large companies in the manufacturing, distribution, and services industries. Infor has been named a “Leader” in Gartner’s Magic Quadrant for Cloud ERP for Product-Centric Enterprises 2022.

Each Infor industry CloudSuite is built with pre-configured processes and setups to cater to the specific needs of the industry. The solutions provided include HR management, procurement, supply chain management, and customer relationship management.

Infor CloudSuite solutions also offer excellent analytics features using pre-configured dashboards with various key performance indicators (KPIs), intuitive reports, and other tools enabling businesses to make better decisions from the insights gained.

Infor offers multiple deployment options including on-premise, cloud, and hybrid giving users the choice to select the most appropriate option for their business needs. Infor is currently investing in strategies to update its ecosystem using AI and Machine Learning.

Infor at a Glance

Company Name: **Infor Inc**

Founded: **2002**

Headquarters: **New York**

Ownership: **Private**

Customers: **90,000+**

Deployment Model: **Cloud, On-Premise**

Modules: Finance & Accounting, Human Capital Management, Supply Chain Management, Planning & Scheduling, Project Management, Customer & Order Management

Microsoft Dynamics 365

Microsoft Dynamics 365 is one of the top cloud-based enterprise systems that combines the capabilities of an ERP system and an advanced CRM system. Microsoft Dynamics has been positioned as a Leader in the 2022 Magic Quadrant for Cloud ERPs for Product-Centric Enterprises.

The Dynamics 365 ERP platform includes versions of its legacy ERP system Microsoft Dynamics AX and Microsoft Dynamics CRM. It is mainly targeted at organizations in the small and mid-market space. Unlike other ERP systems in the market, Microsoft focuses on key business groups rather than specific industries.

The Dynamics 365 suite consists of multiple applications built for different business functionalities including Sales, Marketing, Customer Service, Field Service, Project Service Automation, Finance, Supply Chain Management, Commerce, and Human Resources.

Microsoft Dynamics 365 at a Glance

Company Name: **Microsoft**

Founded: **2001**

Headquarters: **Redmond, WA**

Ownership: **Public**

Customers: **40,000+**

Deployment Model: **Cloud, On-Premise**

Modules: Sales, Marketing, Service, Commerce, Supply Chain, Finance

Microsoft Dynamics 365 helps companies operate more efficiently by automating their processes with intelligent workflows using the inbuilt Cortana Intelligence and Azure machine learning capabilities. Its tight integrations with Microsoft office tools and LinkedIn can boost your productivity considerably.

Microsoft Dynamics 365 which is designed to be a SaaS application, offers other deployment options as well including hosted and on-premises, but with some limited capabilities.

Oracle

Oracle is one of the leading ERP software vendors in the market today. Oracle offers ERP solutions for small, midsize, large, and global enterprises.

Oracle Cloud ERP is the solution built for midsize, large and global enterprises. It includes core financials, accounting hub, purchasing, project management, planning and budgeting, supply chain and manufacturing capabilities, risk management as well as industry-specific applications. Oracle is recognized as a leader in Gartner Magic Quadrant for Cloud ERPs in 2022. Oracle ERP Cloud's Adaptive Intelligent Apps and IoT programs embed technologies such as AI to support product-centric enterprises.

NetSuite is the cloud-based ERP Solution from Oracle targeted at small and medium-sized enterprises. NetSuite named a leader by Gartner in its 2021 magic quadrant for Cloud Core Financial Management Systems for Midsize, Large and Global Enterprises,

has one of the best financial management modules offering real-time access to live financial data. With direct links between accounting and compliance management, users can benefit from accelerated closings and accurate reporting. It also offers excellent capabilities for customer relationship management and marketing automation. It has also been recognized as a visionary in Gartner Magic Quadrant for Cloud ERPs in 2022.

Oracle at a Glance

Company Name: **Oracle Corporation**
Founded: **1977**
Headquarters: **Redmond, WA**
Ownership: **Public**
Customers: **30,000+**
Deployment Model: **Cloud**
Modules: Financials, Procurement, Project Management, Risk Management & Compliance, Enterprise Performance Management, Supply Chain & Manufacturing, ERP Analytics

SAP

SAP continues to be a leader in enterprise applications with more than 25% market share. SAP in fact has three distinct ERP products – SAP S/4 Hana, SAP Business One, and SAP Business by Design. While SAP S/4 HANA is the solution for mid-sized to large enterprises, SAP Business One and SAP Business by Design are SAP's products for small and medium-sized enterprises. SAP is a Visionary in the Gartner Magic Quadrant for Cloud ERPs.

SAP ERPs support business processes including financials, purchasing, inventory, sales, project management, operations, and customer relationships.

SAP focuses on industries including consumer products, manufacturing, retail, distribution, and professional services. SAP ERPs offer all-encompassing out of the box functionalities which allows businesses to manage all their critical information in a single solution. SAP ERPs work on top of the SAP HANA database which enables fast, complex, and robust business analytics giving businesses an advantage for critical decision making. SAP ERPs can be deployed on-premise or cloud.

SAP at a Glance

Company Name: **SAP**
Founded: **1972**
Headquarters: **Walldorf, Germany**
Ownership: **Public**
Customers: **70,000+**
Deployment Model: **On-Premise, Cloud**
Modules: Asset Management, Finance, Manufacturing, R&D and Engineering, Sales, Service, Sourcing & Procurement, Supply Chain

A Quick Comparison of Top ERPs

If you compare the functionalities or modules of these ERP systems, they will be very similar to each other. However, each one might have specific strong points compared to others. For example, Epicor and Infor offer very strong industry-specific functionalities for manufacturers, SAP Business One offers strong BI capabilities, NetSuite excels in Finance Management, MS Dynamics is strong when it comes to customer relationship management, and so on. Identifying which ERP system fits your processes and business needs the best is the key to your ERP implementation success.

Find below a quick summary of comparison of these products, based on organization size, deployment options, costs, features/strengths, etc.

	EPICOR	IFS	infor	Microsoft Dynamics 365	ORACLE	SAP
Organization size	Medium to Large	Medium to Large	Medium to Large	Small to medium sized	Oracle Cloud -Medium to large Oracle NetSuite - Small to medium sized	SAP B1 – small to mid-sized SAP Business By Design – Medium sized, SAP S/4HANA
Business Complexity	Low to high	Low to high	Low to high	Low to medium	Low to high	High
Product Features/ Strengths	Strong Industry specific functionalities Strong financial module Uses advanced technologies – IoT integration, AI based Virtual Agent (EVA), advanced	Good feature set including advanced technology usage like AI, IoT, etc.	Strong Industry specific functionalities	Good CRM features	Good feature set including advanced technology usage like AI, IoT, etc. NetSuite has the best financial management module	Very strong real-time business analytics delivered by SAP HANA
Deployment Options	On-Prem/- Cloud (Public and Private Cloud)	On-Prem/- Cloud	On-Prem/- Cloud	Designed for Cloud but offer On-prem as well (with limited capabilities)	Cloud	On-prem/- Cloud

Latest Technology Capabilities (Cloud, mobile apps, AI/ML and other advanced technology initiatives)	Excellent	Good	Good	Excellent	Excellent	Good
Functionality for mid-size enterprises	Excellent	Good	Good	Excellent	Good	Good
Industry Specific Solutions	Excellent	Excellent	Excellent	Good	Good	Excellent
License Model	Concurrent user	Named user	Named user	Named user	Named user	Named user
Flexibility and Customizations	Highly flexible and easily customizable	Highly flexible and easily customizable	Highly flexible and easily customizable	Highly flexible and easily customizable	Can be customized, but the system becomes complex to manage	Rigid system, Customization is very costly
Ease of Integration using standard API and Tools	Good Integrations	Good Integrations	Average	Good Integration with Microsoft tools but not so great with other software	Good Integrations	Good Integrations
Implementation Time	Less	Less	High	Less	Oracle Cloud - High	Very High
User Experience	Good	Average	Good	Good	Good	Complex
Total Cost of Ownership	Low	Average	Average	High (High customization and maintenance costs)	High (High maintenance costs)	Very high (high deployment, customization and maintenance costs)
Payback time	Faster	Moderate	Moderate	Longer due to high cost of ownership	Longer due to high cost of ownership	Longest due to high cost of ownership and complex implementation

Choosing your ERP – Next Steps

To help you in the process of choosing the best fit ERP system for your Business, here is a comprehensive 8 step checklist that you can rely on.

1 | Define your business requirements

The very first step in selecting the appropriate ERP system for your business is evaluating your business processes and setting your expectations from the ERP system. Identify bottlenecks and pain points in your existing system and determine how ERP software can fit into your process to transform your operations and improve business performance.

2 | Establish an ERP vendor selection criteria

Now that you have identified your business needs, you should identify features and functions in an ERP system that can help you sort them out. Visualize what features the ideal ERP for your business should offer and list them out.

Here is a list of factors to be considered for your ERP selection criteria:

Industry-specific functionalities

Look for any industry-specific functionalities that you want in your ERP system. For example, if you are a discrete manufacturer, you may have to consider your needs like Material Requirements Planning, Bill of Material management, features supporting your manufacturing methodology like lean manufacturing features, etc. There are many industry-specific ERP systems in the market today and choosing an ERP system with industry-specific functionalities that you require can minimize the need for customizations to your ERP.

Scalability

An ideal ERP system should be able to grow with your business and can adapt to your growing business needs. It should just not be meeting your current needs; the system should scale to support your future needs as well when you expand – that may mean more users or more capabilities.

Deployment Option

Do you want to implement a cloud or on-premise ERP? Cloud ERP of course is the trend in recent years due to benefits like cost savings, easy deployment, more mobility, reduced risks, and scalability as well as enablement of remote work

Integrations

The ERP solution that you select should easily integrate with your current software that you would like to use alongside your ERP or what you may have to use in the future. Only if the ERP system integrates well with your other systems, you can enjoy a fully automated end to end software solution, which in fact, is the real purpose of implementing an ERP system.



Flexibility, configurability and customizations

Despite having comprehensive functionalities, the ERP you choose should also be flexible enough to allow configuration and if need be, customizations of your company-specific business processes.

Reporting and analytics

Modern businesses demand reports that help boost your decision-making capabilities. Hence, you should look for ERP systems including the latest reporting and analytics features like Business Intelligence, real-time tracking, and analytics that help transform the data into actionable insights to improve your business strategies.

User-friendliness

Your investment in the ERP gets diluted if it cannot be used to its full extent. It's vital that the users of the ERP, your employees can use it effectively as their ability to interact efficiently with the system will impact the ROI of the system. It should support quicker user adoption with a clean interface that is easy to navigate. Training tools and learning materials should also be easily available.

Support for the latest technology trends

The ideal ERP should embrace or at least support integration with the latest technologies like Artificial Intelligence, Internet of Things (IoT), etc. to help you keep pace with emerging trends and stay competitive.

3 | Outline a budget and timescale

Have a clear idea on how much you can spend on the ERP system and have a high-level plan of when you would like your ERP solution to go live. Time for ERP implementations can range anywhere from a few months to even years, based on the size of the business, number of locations and customization required. When working on the budget, you have to consider the potential hidden costs outside of purchasing the software as well including costs for maintenance, resources required, training cost, hardware in case of an on-premise deployment and other utilities that may be required.

4 | Create a list of ERPs fulfilling your selection criteria

So, now that you have your selection criteria and budget set, you can shortlist the ERPs that meet your requirement criteria.

5 | Evaluate and shortlist your ERP vendor options

There may be many vendors meeting your criteria. To select the best, you have to do a thorough evaluation of the vendor options. Take into account things like vendor reputation, the vendor's past experience in your industry, vendor's technology direction and viability, customer satisfaction, support and training offered, the total cost of ownership etc.

You can contact each of the vendors you have shortlisted and have a conversation with them to understand their potential.

6 | Schedule ERP vendor demos

When you have identified potential vendors, seek out more information and schedule product demos. Many of the vendors may send a representative to give you a demo in house and some vendors may even have online product demos and free trials. Take full advantage of these demos and free trials to clarify your uncertainties and experience the product in action to get a real feel of it.

7 | Conduct a comparison and use a scoring system to quantify your research results

With all the evaluation and insights from the demos, you would have come to 3 or 4 of the best fits. Compare them using a scoring system for various features you need so that you can quantify how well each system meets your needs and measure up against each other. This is a great way to find the best fit from the lot.

8 | Make your decision and agree on the final terms with the ERP vendor

Make sure that you have a clear Statement of Work (SOW) with the vendor before you initiate the actual project. The SOW should identify scope, timelines, milestones and costs to avoid any ambiguity at a later date.

Epicor ERP in Comparison to Other Leading ERP Solutions in the Market

Based on a report by TEC (Technology Evaluation Centres is an impartial software analysis firm), Epicor ERP was assessed to determine its coverage of eight key domains, with 3,539 features and compared against the average ERP software on the market. Here's how it fares in each of the eight modules:



Financial Management

Epicor financial software offers robust multi-company, multi-plant or multi-warehouse operations, as well as inter-company transaction processing, and meets the needs of strong financial management on a global basis. The financial module offers a full range of financial reports, including journal listings, general ledger and trial balance reports, and a full set of financial statements. The solution covers 96% of financial features requested/required by companies in comparison to the average 90% coverage of the average ERP software in the market for this module.



Manufacturing Management

Epicor ERP solutions manufacturing capabilities include shipping and receiving, quality assurance, inventory and material management, purchasing, project management and job scheduling, sales, CRM, and quoting and order management. The solution optimizes lean manufacturing to focus on the key priorities to make smarter decisions, eliminate waste and increase customer satisfaction. Epicor ERP covers 97% of Manufacturing Management functions against 81% by the average market solution.

Based on Technology evaluation Centres' report, Epicor ERP is an ERP software that can nicely compete with top solutions in the manufacturing realm, demonstrating high functionality particularly in the discrete and ETO manufacturing models.



Inventory Management

Epicor ERP (Enterprise Resource Planning) Inventory Management helps to streamline the entire inventory process. For example, the Epicor ERP quoting function pulls data from inventory to help job shops provide customers with more accurate quotes and delivery schedules by building variables into the quote. Variables such as inventory status, outstanding customer orders, and future delivery dates enable sales to provide customers with costs and delivery dates based on real time information. Epicor ERP offers 92% coverage of Inventory Management features. This surpasses its competitor average of 86% for this module.



Purchasing Management

Epicor's Purchase Management module streamlines purchase order writing and tracking of supplier performance with automated purchasing tools to improve supplier collaboration, order accuracy and negotiations. It also reduces inventory levels and improves on-time deliveries for better cash flow with cross-referencing, mass purchase order receipts, requisition tracking and more. In this module, Epicor ERP supports 98% of the required functionalities. This challenges the average 91% of Purchasing Management features and functions available in other solutions.



Quality Management

Epicor Advanced Quality Management (AQM) is an extension of the Quality Assurance offering. AQM puts companies in a constant state of compliance. AQM capabilities include employee training and skills, managing document revisions and changes, work instructions, non-conformance and corrective actions, gauges, equipment as well as a detailed statistical process control (SPC) function. Epicor ERP covers 98% of Quality Management attributes required in an ERP in comparison to an average 82% of its competitors.



Sales Management

Epicor Sales Management module automates labour-intensive processes for proposal generation, configuration and quoting. It also automates order entry to improve sales productivity by increasing accuracy during the quote and order processes. In the Sales Management module, Epicor ERP has 95% coverage of features and functions. The average support offered by other ERP suites is 90%.





Product Technology

The service-oriented architecture (SOA) provides midmarket businesses with the ability to easily and efficiently align information systems and technology resources. Epicor ERP is an end-to-end solution with a single source for all software needs. The solution is supported by a global services and support organization that provides efficient implementation services. The technology architecture, design of the user interface and several options for deployment makes the solution robust from a functional standpoint and provides an overall low total cost of ownership. Epicor ERP supports 83% of Product Technology characteristics and outpaces the average competitor (66%).

RheinBrücke's Epicor Solutions

RheinBrücke believes that a successful ERP implementation is very crucial as it impacts almost every aspect of your business. We help our customers to implement Epicor ERP solutions that can enhance operational efficiency and business performance with better control over processes. Here is how we ensure successful and cost-effective ERP implementations that allow our customers to get the most of their ERP and get faster ROI.



Industry Specific Solutions

We offer Industry Vertical Template Solutions for Epicor ERP for various industries like Discrete Manufacturing, Process Manufacturing, Cable Manufacturing, Interior Design, EPC, etc, based on proven best practices aggregated from our multiple industry implementations across the world. The industry specific features in these solutions to meet the diverse needs of the industry processes help minimize customizations and accelerate implementation.



Deployment on the RheinBrücke Cloud

The solution is deployed on the highly secure RheinBrücke Cloud hosted in the Moro Hub Datacenter. The modern cloud deployment gives you added advantages of lower cost, flexibility and frees up your time and resources spent on maintenance. Maintenance, Security and Business continuity are all part and parcel of the solution.



Learning and Training

We offer a comprehensive Learning Management platform – RheinBrücke Academy to our customers to ensure effective training of end users as well as key users and administrators. The platform provides interactive simulation-based learning content which ensures 100% module coverage for all your users to ensure effective change management, increase user adoption and getting the most of your implementation.



Implementation using SCALE Methodology

RheinBrücke's standardized SCALE implementation methodology driven by industry best practices ensures a successful ERP implementation in a short time span by minimizing risk and maximizing predictability with clearly defined deliverables and processes. It is a scalable approach for implementation that is designed to address your needs based on the foundation elements – Solutioning, Consulting Expertise, Agile Practices, Learning and Enablement. We offer three types of ERP implementations standardized using the SCALE methodology, namely – Rapid, Fast and Standard based on the number of users and the customizations needed for the implementation.



Support

Our omnichannel support driven by a robust ticketing system ensures that your business users always have the support and help readily available from our large pool of Epicor certified professional engineers who have worked on multiple complex global ERP implementations.



Conclusion

The future of ERP systems in 2024 is poised for significant growth and evolution. Whether a business is in the process of outgrowing entry-level software or replacing an outdated legacy system, selecting an ERP solution that incorporates cutting-edge technologies like Machine Learning, Artificial Intelligence (AI), and the Internet of Things (IoT) will be pivotal in shaping future success and profitability. The design of the software, the quality of the integration tools and the experience of the integration partner all have a vital role to play. As we have seen, an ERP system is applicable to any organization that needs to improve the efficiency and flexibility of its processes. Quick implementation is especially significant to smaller-midsize organizations because of their requirements for low cost and rapid time-to-benefit.

The 7 software solutions compared in this document were chosen because they represent a reasonable sample of ERP solutions in the EMEA region. By comparing Epicor ERP's functionality to the support offered by the average ERP software, we are able to analyse the success ratio of the Epicor solution. Aberdeen's Sector Insight on the "Total Cost of ERP Ownership for Mid-Size Companies" included comparisons to 6 major ERP providers, based on responses from the 645 mid-size companies surveyed. The results showed that on average Epicor software costs less to purchase, implement and to maintain on a per-user basis. The survey also revealed that Epicor customers implement over 8% more modules when compared to other mid-size companies using competitive solutions whether Tier 1 or SMB focused. It is important that software buyers carefully identify which modules are critical to their success and ensure that the selected software offers sufficient coverage in those specific areas. With advanced business technologies, a product like Epicor ERP makes competing in global and emerging markets within the scope of virtually every commercial enterprise. We understand that choosing an ERP that is best suited to your requirements is very crucial and involves evaluating multiple options available in the market. We recommend checking out the ratings and reviews of top enterprise technology solutions by end-user professionals on Gartner Peer Insights. Organizations that strategically invest in ERP systems tailored to their needs and embrace these technological advancements will be well-positioned for growth, increased profitability, and enhanced operational efficiency in the years to come.

About RheinBrücke

RheinBrücke is a European company with global mindset and a strong footprint in Europe, Middle East, and India. We have immense experience and expertise in providing Enterprise Business Solutions, Surround IT Solutions, Consulting Services and Product Development Services to clients globally across 42 countries. RheinBrücke's flagship product, MeRLIN is an integrated solution for Direct & Indirect Sourcing with Supplier Relationship Management, Sourcing Automation and Planning augmented by Advanced Analytics. RheinBrücke is also an Epicor Premium Partner and two times winner of International Partner of the Year, as well as Microsoft Gold Partner. Our team of experts with Six Sigma and PMP as well as our proprietary SCALE Methodology certification can deliver robust enterprise solutions and offerings to address the needs of businesses on multiple verticals including Automotive Suppliers, Discrete & Process Manufacturing, Engineering, Procurement & Construction, Retail & Distribution and Public Sector. Our strong distribution channel across the globe supported by our robust RheinBrücke Academy based training and omnichannel support ensures seamless delivery of solutions and services. With a deep understanding of what it takes for enterprises to succeed, RheinBrücke helps clients adapt to a changing marketplace by ensuring their IT ecosystems are relevant, efficient, and perfectly tuned.

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